FREE CARDS

Periods: My Visual Routine

Twelve step cards for managing a period at home and at school, plus a bag checklist, a product comparison and a leak plan.

WHO IT IS FOR

Autistic girls, young women and anyone who has periods, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE

Primary · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA

Easy read

A period is blood from the vagina. It is normal. I use a pad or period pants. I know what to do.

How to use this resource

- Teach the routine **before** the first period. Practise with a clean pad on a dry day.
- Cut out the 12 step cards. Put them in order on a ring, on the bathroom wall or in the school bag.
- Use the bag checklist to pack a spare kit. Keep a second kit at school with a trusted adult.
- Try the products in the sensory table at home first. Choose what feels right. There is no wrong choice.
- Agree the leak plan with school. Everyone should know the plan, and say the same words.

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Version 1.0 · periods-visual-routine

My period steps

A period is when blood comes out of the vagina. It usually lasts three to seven days. Follow the steps in order.

1



Notice

I see blood on my underwear or I feel wet. I stay calm. This is a period.

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2



Go to the toilet

I go to the toilet or bathroom. I lock the door.

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3



Get my kit

I take my pad, period pants or tampon from my bag.

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4



Wash my hands

I wash my hands with soap before I touch anything.

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5



Take off the used one

I remove the used pad or change my pants. I roll up the pad.

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6



Wrap and bin

I wrap it in toilet paper or the bag. I put it in the sanitary bin. I never flush it.

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7



Put on a new one

I peel the paper strip and stick the pad to my underwear. I check it is flat.

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8



Check my clothes

I check my clothes for marks. I pull up my underwear and clothes.

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9



Wash my hands again

I wash my hands with soap and water.

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10



Check the time

I change my pad every 4 to 6 hours, or when it is full.

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11



Look after me

I drink water. I rest if I need to. A hot water bottle can help sore tummies.

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12



Done

I go back to my day. If I have a problem I ask a trusted adult.

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My school-bag checklist

Pack this period kit in a small pouch. Keep it in your school bag all month, because periods can start any time.

- ☐ 2 to 3 pads or period pants (the kind I like)
- ☐ A spare pair of underwear
- ☐ A small plastic bag for a used item or wet clothes
- ☐ Wipes (unscented if smells bother me)
- ☐ Spare tights or leggings, or a school jumper to tie around my waist
- ☐ Pain relief only if my parent or GP has said it is okay, and the school knows
- ☐ A card with the plan: 'Tell [name]. Go to [place].'
- ☐ A water bottle

Products: how they feel

There are different products. Try them at home. Choose what feels comfortable. You can use more than one kind. Start with pads or period pants: they are simple. Ask the pharmacist, GP or public health nurse if you have questions.

Product	How it feels	Noise	How often to change	Notes
Pads (disposable)	Stick to underwear. Feel like a thick strip. Can feel wet and bunchy.	Wrapper rustles. Sticky strip can make a small noise when opened.	Every 4 to 6 hours, or when full	Easy to use. Choose cotton or unscented. Different sizes for light or heavy days.
Period pants	Soft, like underwear with a built-in pad. Feel the weight when wet.	Quiet.	Change when full, about every 8 to 12 hours depending on the brand	Rinse in cold water, then wash. Carry a wet bag for school.
Tampons	Sit inside the vagina. Many people cannot feel them when in place.	Wrapper rustles.	Every 4 to 8 hours. Never leave in more than 8 hours.	Take practice. Read the leaflet. Some people prefer not to use them. That is okay.
Menstrual cup	Soft silicone cup that sits inside. Many people cannot feel it when in place.	Quiet.	Empty every 8 to 12 hours, depending on flow	Takes practice and a private bathroom with a sink. Wash well. Not for everyone.

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If I leak at school

A leak happens to most people who have periods. It is not your fault. It is not a big deal. Here is the plan.

1



Stay calm

Breathe slowly. Leaks happen to many people.

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2



Cover

Tie a jumper or coat around my waist.

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3



Tell

Tell my trusted adult: 'I have a leak. I need my kit.'

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4



Go to the bathroom

I change my pad and underwear.

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5



Bag

Put wet clothes in my plastic bag.

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6



Back to class

I wash my hands and go back.

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To a teacher, SNA or secretary



I need to go to the bathroom. It is a period thing.

To a trusted adult



I have a leak. Can you help me get my kit?

If someone says something unkind



That is private. Please stop.

Period tracker and calendar tip

Mark the first day of each period on a calendar, or on a phone app. After a few months you may see a pattern. A tracker helps you know when to expect your next period. Periods can be irregular for the first few years. That is normal.

My period tracker

First day of this period: _____

Last day of this period: _____

How I felt (sore, tired, happy, other): _____

What helped me: _____

Notes for adults

- Prepare early and practise. Many autistic girls get their first period without warning if they were not told. Start before 9 years old.
- Go through the steps with a real pad. Let the child hold it, feel it and put it on at home first.
- Allow time. Offer a sensory-friendly bathroom, a visual timetable, and a pass to leave class without explanation.
- Do not assume ability. Some young people will manage alone. Others will need support. Offer support in a way that keeps privacy and dignity.
- Ask your child's GP if periods are very heavy, very painful, or cause worry. Pain that stops daily life should be checked.
- Keep a spare kit at school with a named adult. Agree the plan and the words with the school.
- Free period products are available in schools and other places in Ireland. Check with your school or local council.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand unit *Growing and changing* (5th and 6th class): menstruation as part of puberty, within the RSE programme.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality** and Strand 2 **Making Healthy Choices**: managing periods and hygiene.
- Senior Cycle SPHE (new specification, 2024) and LCA Social Education: practical life skills and personal care.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: teach routines step by step, with practice.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Your GP or public health nurse

For questions about puberty, periods, body changes or health checks.

HSE Sexual Wellbeing

Free information, free STI testing and free contraception information at sexualwellbeing.ie.

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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